

CORPUS OF HISTORICAL LOW GERMAN



A Corpus for Middle Low German

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New Methods in Historical Corpora

1



Introduction

- Middle Low German: dialects spoken between 1250 and 1600 in northern Germany
- International *lingua franca* around North and Baltic Seas in 14th and 15th centuries in connection with the Hanseatic League
- Certain standardization of written forms incorporating features of different dialects (*regionale Schreibsprachen*)
- Replaced as the written language by (Early New) High German between 1550 and 1650
- LG continues to exist in spoken dialects



Introduction

- Historical Low German syntax is an under-researched field
- Unlike for e.g. older English, there are no tagged and parsed corpora available yet
- A few texts are available in TITUS, but searchable only for word forms, not syntactically parsed
- Sundquist (2007) for MLG on a very small scale; based on parts of the *Codex Diplomaticus Lubecensis*
- *Atlas spätmittelalterlicher Schreibsprachen des niederdeutschen Altlandes und angrenzender Gebiete* (ASnA) (Peters et al., to appear 2013): focus on delineating scribal dialects, i.e., phonological and morphological variation; maps of dialect forms



A Corpus of Historical Low German

- *Plan*: to build a modern corpus of historical Low German (CHLG):
 - Old Low German (OLG) / Old Saxon (OS) c. 800–1050
 - Middle Low German (MLG) c. 1250–1600 PILOT
- Key principles for CHLG:
 - Text selection
 - Corpus properties



A Corpus of Historical Low German

1. Text selection:

- (a) prose
- (b) not translated
- (c) clearly dated and localized

e.g. charters, diplomatic codices, court verdicts: key text-types in MLG

- cf. Lasch (1987:V) and Peters (1997: 179) on the importance of charters and the role of towns and their records for MLG
- Historical Dutch: van Reenen and Mulder (2000) for MDu. Coupé and van Kemenade (2009) for “Dutch in Transition” (1400-1700)



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- Advantages of these text-types:
 - Edited texts are available for a large number of places
 - Relative homogeneity of style and content leads to a high level of comparability
 - Long time-span of many texts and geographical spread makes possible a fine-grained modelling of linguistic change through both time and space, offering potential insights into dialect contact and the emergence of regional standards
 - Avoidance of chronological gaps



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- Disadvantages:
 - The use of edited texts for Phase 1 will make the CHLG unsuitable for orthographic / phonological work.
 - For our own work, the quality of the editions can be expected to give problems with the marking of word boundaries

Detailed correction of the texts based on archival MSS will be a later phase in the project.



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- Phase I: *Urkundenbücher* and similar texts from four important scribal dialects of MLG: three are regional, Hansa cities are treated separately

Westphalian	Eastphalian	North Low Saxon	Hansa cities
Börstel	Barsinghausen	Oldenburg	Lübeck
Steinfurt	Braunschweig	Scharnebeck	Stralsund
	Mariengarten	Uelzen	

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Map





A Corpus of Historical Low German

- We have already obtained permission from the copyright holders to digitize, tag and parse these texts (but not yet for open access on the WWW)
- We have secured a small Newton Trust grant for a pilot run on one text (*Urkundenbuch des Stifts Börstel*) to estimate better the amount of time and money needed for the whole corpus
- We are preparing a larger grant proposal for the entire MLG corpus to be submitted later this year (2011)



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- Time and funding permitting, the corpus will eventually be extended to cover:
 - Old Low German (Old Saxon): already digitized, but not yet parsed and tagged
 - MLG literary texts to counter-balance the formulaic style of the charters/legal texts and create a more representative sample
- Necessarily these texts will not comply with our text selection criteria outlined above.



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2. Corpus properties

The corpus will follow the successful Penn-York-Helsinki corpora of historical English, and more recently, the IcePaHC corpus of historical Icelandic (Wallenberg *et al.* 2011)

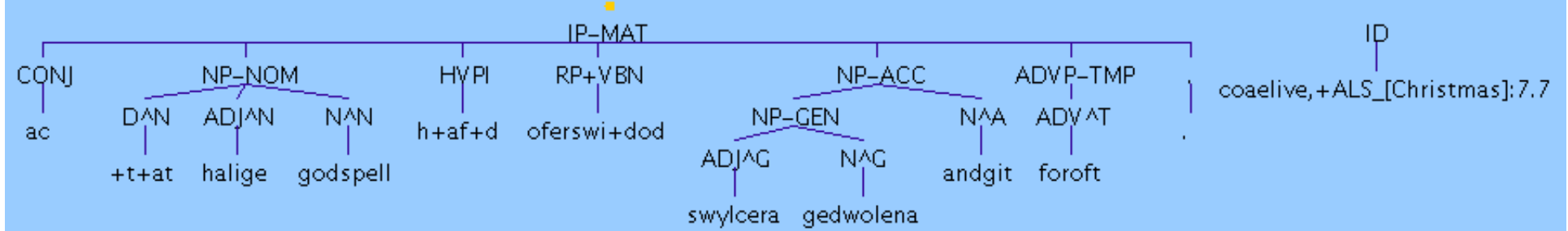
- this enables easy comparison between Germanic languages, as well as within Low German itself
- The corpus will be provided in three forms:
 - (a) Text (.txt)
 - (b) Part-of-speech tagged (.pos)
 - (c) Parsed (.psd)



A Corpus of Historical Low German

Penn-York-Helsinki annotation scheme:

- largely theory-neutral



- established standard for which software already exists



Case study

Advantages of this type of corpus:

- Comparability with existing such corpora
- Facilitation of quantitative studies
- Possible to search for syntactic structures and parts of speech, not just (collocations of) literal strings
- Case study below to show the type of things we will be able to do much better with such a corpus (this work was originally carried out ‘manually’)



Case study

- *Case study*: The speed of Jespersen's Cycle (Breitbarth 2008)
- Future directions (Walkden forthcoming, Watts forthcoming)



Case study

The speed of Jespersen's Cycle in Low German

- Jespersen's Cycle (JC):
 - Directional diachronic development affecting negators
 - “the original negative adverb is first weakened, then found insufficient and therefore strengthened, generally through some additional word, and this in its turn may be felt as the negative proper and may then in the course of time be subject to the same development as the original word”
(Jespersen 1917:4)



Case study

- In OLG (=OS), negation was via a preverbal (clitic) particle (stage I of JC)
 - (1) ‘*ni* bium ic’, quad he, ‘that barn godes...’
NEG am I spoke he the child God.GEN
‘I am not the child of God, he said’ (*Heliand* XI, 915)
 - This particle was very rarely ‘reinforced’ through use of an adverbial indefinite *((n)io)uuiht* ‘nothing > (not) at all’
 - (2) Ne ik thi geth *ni* deriu *(neo)uuiht* quad he.
and.not I you also NEG damage nothing said he
‘I will also not harm you at all’ (*Heliand* XLVII, 3892)



Case study

- MLG: stage II > III of Jespersen's cycle
- Early MLG: stage II
 - (2) We des *nicht en* wete de latis sik berichten.
who this.GEN NEG EN knows REL let.it REFL report
'(Everyone) who does not (yet) know this, should endeavour to
learn about it' (Braunschweig 1349)
- Preverbal *ne/en* no longer expresses negation on its own (cf. Breitbarth 2009)



Case study

- Later MLG and present-day LG: Stage III
 - *ne/en* may not co-occur with *nicht*
- (3) Eyne fruwe de schwanger iß mag men *nicht* dringen tho dem eyde
a woman who pregnant is may one NEG force to the oath
'A pregnant woman must not be forced to take an oath'
(Braunschweig 24/02/1553)
- *nicht* is clearly the expression of standard negation



Case study

- Overview of JC in LG:

Stage I	Stage II	Stage III	
OLG (=OS)	MLG		ModLG
<i>ni</i> .. V _{fin}	<i>ne/en</i> .. V _{fin} .. <i>nicht</i>	V _{fin} .. <i>nicht</i>	
ex. (1)	ex. (2)	ex. (3)	

- Breitbarth (2008): the different scribal dialects of MLG make the transition from stage II to stage III of JC at different speeds



Case study

- The old preverbal negator is lost much faster in the north and esp. in the north-eastern Hanse cities than in the Saxon *Altland*

	Westphalian	Eastphalian	North Low Saxon	Hanse cities
1325-1374	22 (78.6%)	56 (72.7%)	37 (56.1%)	3 (50%)
1375-1424	25 (80.6%)	52 (71.2%)	42 (33.1%)	12 (18.5%)
1425-1474	4 (44.4%)	25 (52.1%)	75 (33%)	20 (29%)
1475-1524	19 (43.2%)	15 (14.6%)	62 (31.2%)	10 (7.8 %)
1525-1574	10 (25%)	18 (10.2%)	3 (12%)	2 (12.5%)
total	81 (53.3%)	166 (34.7%)	219 (34%)	47 (16.5%)



Case study

- Goldvarb identified the factor group ‘dialect’ as significant (besides period of composition, position of the verb, and type of verb)
- The probability of a clause negated with *nicht* containing preverbal *en/ne* is much higher in Westphalian than any of the other dialects, and it is much lower in the Hansa cities:

Westphalian: 0.769

Eastphalian: 0.585

North Low Saxon: 0.475

Hansa cities: 0.278



Case study

- Accelerated transition to stage III of JC in the north-east can be accounted for under an urbanization scenario (dialect levelling, koinéization):
- Lübeck and Stralsund were centres of Hanseatic trade at the time, founded after the OLG period on formerly Slavonic land by settlers from NLS and WP areas
- Dialect levelling because of adult ‘bidialectalism’ – accommodation; simplification (Trudgill 1994: 19)



Case study

- What a corpus like the proposed could have achieved here:
 - (i) Automated search for all negative/NPI/‘free’ indefinites
 - (ii) Automated search for negators/negative markers
 - (iii) Quantitative evaluation of co-occurrences
 - (iv) Search for determining factors such as dialect
 - (v) Provision of quantitative information on the above
- can help research the spread of a linguistic change in both space and time



Future directions

- Walkden (forthcoming) looks at verb position in main clauses in OLG (=OS): V1/V2 near-ubiquitous, *unlike* in Old English where certain (e.g. pronominal) subjects precede the verb. Based on manual search of *Heliand*
- Watts (forthcoming) tracks the replacement of prefixed verbs (e.g. OLG/OS *astandan*) by particle verbs in MLG (e.g. *up stan*): claims for MLG are based on a small number of texts manually searched

→ extend to a broad range of MLG texts...



Conclusion

- Difficult at present to make any representative claims about Middle Low German
- With a parsed corpus, (dis)continuities between OLG (OS) and MLG can be tracked
- MLG will become available for comparative studies with Middle English, Dutch and High German



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CORPUS OF HISTORICAL LOW GERMAN



Corpus

OLG (=OS):

- *Heliand und Genesis*. Ed. by E. Sievers. Halle: Buchhandlung des Waisenhauses, 1878.
- *Kleinere altsächsische sprachdenkmäler. Mit anmerkungen und glossar*. Ed. by E. Wadstein. Norden/Leipzig: D. Soltau's Verlag, 1899.

MLG:

- *Urkundenbuch des Klosters Barsinghausen*. Bearb. von A. Bonk. Hannover: Hahn, 1996.
- *Urkundenbuch des Stifts Börstel*. Bearb. von R. Rölker & W. Delbanco. Osnabrück: Selbstverlag des Vereins für Geschichte und Landeskunde von Osnabrück. 1996.
- *Urkundenbuch der Stadt Braunschweig*. Hg. von L. Hänselmann, H. Mack, M.R.W. Garzmann & J. Dolle. Osnabrück: Wenner, 1975.
- *Urkundenbuch der Diözese Lübeck*. Vol. 1 bearb. Von W. Leverkus (1856), vols. 2–5 bearb. von W. Prange. Neumünster: Wachholtz. 1994–1997.



Corpus

- *Urkundenbuch des Klosters Mariengarten*. Bearb. von M. von Boetticher. Hildesheim: Lax. 1987.
- *Urkundenbuch der Stadt Oldenburg*. Bearb. von D. Kohl. Münster: Aschendorff. 1914.
- *Urkundenbuch des Klosters Scharnebeck: 1243–1531*. Bearb. von D. Brosius. Hildesheim: Lax. 1979.
- *Inventar des Fürstlichen Archivs zu Burgsteinfurt*. Bearb. von A. Bruns & W. Kohl. Hrsg. von A. Bruns. Münster Westf.: Aschendorff, 1971–1983.
- *Der Stralsunder liber memorialis*. (Veröffentlichungen des Stadtarchivs Stralsund. Hg. Herbert Ewe). Bearb. v. Horst-Diether Schroeder.
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 - Teil 2: Fol. 61–120, 1410–1422. Weimar: Hermann Böhlau Nachfolger. 1969.
 - Teil 3: Fol. 121–186, 1423–1440. Weimar: Hermann Böhlau Nachfolger. 1972.
 - Teil 4: Fol. 187–240, 1366–1426. Rostock: Hinstorff Verlag. 1966.
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